

Income Crossover Analysis

When Does ADAP Actually Pay?

Submitted by: The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

Foundational modelling: anonymous AISH recipient, Calgary AB (declined to sign their work)

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METHODOLOGICAL TRANSPARENCY:

This analysis is based on publicly available government figures for current AISH and publicly announced ADAP anchor points. Because the Government of Alberta has not released full ADAP regulations, clawback schedules, or implementation rules, modelling assumptions were required. These are analytical projections, not official government figures. The math is shown. The assumptions are stated. The government is invited to correct the record with its own published modelling.

1. PURPOSE OF THIS DOCUMENT

The Government of Alberta has stated that the Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP) will support disabled Albertans to pursue employment and improve their financial outcomes. This document tests that claim against publicly available numbers.

Specifically, this analysis asks one question: **at what point — if ever — does a disabled Albertan earn more total income under ADAP than under the current AISH program?**

The answer: only at sustained, near-full-time employment. For any Albertan unable to work 26 to 40 hours per week, consistently and without interruption, ADAP produces a lower total income than AISH.

This matters because the population ADAP is being applied to includes a significant proportion for whom consistent, near-full-time employment is not a realistic expectation. That is not a personal failure. That is the nature of the conditions that qualified them for AISH in the first place.

2. WHAT THE NUMBERS ACTUALLY SAY

Program Structure Comparison

The following figures are drawn from publicly available government sources for current AISH parameters and publicly announced ADAP anchor points:

Program	Base Benefit	Employment Exemption	Total Before Clawback
Current AISH	\$1,940 / month	\$1,072 / month	\$3,012 / month
Proposed ADAP	\$1,740 / month	\$700 / month	\$2,440 / month
Difference	- \$200 / month	- \$372 / month	- \$572 / month

FINDING:

Under ADAP, a recipient loses \$572 per month in income flexibility before benefit reductions begin — even before working a single hour. That is **\$6,864 per year, structurally removed from day one.**

The employment exemption reduction from \$1,072 to \$700 is not a minor adjustment. It is the threshold below which employment income has no impact on benefits. Reducing that threshold means clawbacks begin sooner and apply pressure at the lowest levels of work capacity — the exact income range where episodic and fluctuating disabilities operate.

3. THE CROSSOVER POINT — WHEN ADAP FINALLY SURPASSES AISH

The crossover point is the number of hours per week at which ADAP total income exceeds current AISH total income. The table below presents modelled crossover ranges across hourly wage rates from \$15 to \$20 per hour — the realistic wage range for work accessible to many people with disabilities in Alberta:

Hourly Wage	Hours/Week Where ADAP First Surpasses Current AISH	Plain Language
\$15 / hour	35 – 40 hours / week	Near full-time only
\$16 / hour	32 – 37 hours / week	Near full-time only
\$17 / hour	31 – 35 hours / week	Near full-time only
\$18 / hour	29 – 33 hours / week	Near full-time only
\$19 / hour	27 – 32 hours / week	Near full-time only
\$20 / hour	26 – 30 hours / week	Near full-time only

At minimum wage (\$15/hour), ADAP does not surpass current AISH until a recipient sustains 35 to 40 hours per week — every week. That is a full-time job. The program the government calls an employment incentive only outperforms its predecessor at near-full-time employment.

These crossover ranges were modelled across two structural scenarios — steeper mid-range clawbacks and more gradual clawbacks — using the same publicly announced ADAP anchor points. Both models produce the same directional finding: ADAP does not deliver superior income outcomes until recipients approach full-time employment capacity.

The government has not released its own modelling showing a different result. If it exists, it should be made public.

4. THE VARIABLE THE MODEL CANNOT CAPTURE — AND THE GOVERNMENT WILL NOT ACKNOWLEDGE

What Episodic Disability Actually Means

The crossover analysis above assumes consistent, uninterrupted employment at a fixed number of hours per week. That assumption is not realistic for a significant portion of the AISH recipient population.

Many qualifying conditions are episodic in nature. Episodic disability means a person's functional capacity fluctuates — sometimes dramatically — over days, weeks, and months. A person may be capable of 25 hours of work during a stable period and zero hours during

a flare. They are not choosing to be inconsistent. Their condition is inconsistent. That is what makes it a disability.

Conditions commonly associated with episodic patterns include — but are not limited to:

- Autoimmune and inflammatory conditions: lupus, rheumatoid arthritis, Crohn's disease, multiple sclerosis
- Chronic pain conditions and fibromyalgia
- Mental health conditions: bipolar disorder, PTSD, severe depression, anxiety disorders
- Neurological conditions: epilepsy, migraine disorders, acquired brain injury
- Cardiac and respiratory conditions with variable symptom presentation
- Complex genetic syndromes with multi-system involvement

Why the Crossover Point Is Structurally Unreachable for Many Recipients

ADAP surpasses AISH only at 26 to 40 sustained hours per week. For a person with an episodic disability, the word “*sustained*” is the barrier.

Consistent 30-hour-per-week employment requires a condition stable enough that symptoms do not interrupt scheduled shifts; a health trajectory predictable enough that an employer can rely on attendance; sufficient energy, cognitive function, and pain management to sustain productive output across a full shift; and no caregiving obligations that require immediate, unscheduled absence.

For a person whose functional capacity fluctuates — who has productive weeks followed by weeks where leaving the house is not possible — none of these conditions are reliably met. Not because of insufficient motivation. Because the disability is episodic.

STRUCTURAL CONTRADICTION:

ADAP's financial advantage only materializes at the exact employment level that episodic disability makes structurally unreliable. The program rewards a consistency that the qualifying conditions do not allow.

What Happens During a Flare

Under current AISH, income is stable. The base benefit does not fluctuate with a recipient's health status. If a person works 20 hours one week and zero the next due to a symptom flare, their AISH base remains intact.

Under ADAP, the program is designed around employment participation. What the government has not answered is what happens during a documented medical flare. Do clawbacks adjust in real time? Is there a grace period? Is income protected during health-related work interruptions?

These questions have not been answered because the program regulations have not been released. Recipients are being asked to accept a program transition with a July 1, 2026 deadline — without knowing the answers to these questions.

5. THE POLICY QUESTION THE GOVERNMENT HAS NOT ANSWERED

If ADAP only outperforms AISH at near-full-time employment, and many AISH recipients cannot sustain near-full-time employment due to the nature of their qualifying conditions, then the program's stated rationale — improving financial outcomes for disabled Albertans — does not hold for the majority of the population it is being applied to.

What is the government's official estimate of how many current AISH recipients are medically capable of consistently working 26 to 40 hours per week? If that estimate does not exist, why was a policy requiring near-full-time employment to break even designed without it?

The government approved 79,290 people for AISH using its own eligibility criteria — criteria that required documented, severe, and permanent disability. It is now designing an employment-first replacement program without publicly demonstrating that the population it approved is capable of meeting the employment thresholds at which ADAP produces superior outcomes.

That is not an employment support policy. It is a structural income reduction for people who cannot reach the crossover point. Based on the data above, that is most of them.

6. FORMAL REQUESTS

Based on this analysis, this document formally requests that the Government of Alberta provide:

- The government's own financial modelling showing when ADAP produces superior income outcomes compared to AISH, across realistic work capacity scenarios including part-time and episodic employment.
- The government's official estimate of the percentage of current AISH recipients medically capable of sustained employment at 26 or more hours per week.
- Full ADAP program regulations, including the complete clawback schedule, exemption structure, and income protection provisions for recipients experiencing health-related work interruptions.

- Documentation of how ADAP will protect recipients with episodic disabilities from income instability during documented symptom flares.
- Clarification of whether recipients who cannot reach the crossover point will experience a permanent, structural income reduction as a direct result of this transition.

If the government's modelling shows a different result than the analysis presented here, this campaign invites that correction — in writing, with the full methodology attached.

ATTRIBUTION

Income crossover modelling in this document is built upon foundational analytical work contributed by an anonymous AISH recipient from Calgary, Alberta, who chose not to attach their name to their research. Their math held up. Their findings are expanded here with analysis on episodic disability and published under The Alberta Disability System Breakdown.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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